

Lion

Panthera leo

Lions are the most social species of cat. They form units called prides, consisting of a group of adult females that share a home range with their young and up to three adult males. Prides have just four or five members where food is scarce, such as the Namibian semi-desert, and at least a dozen in East Africa's prey-rich savannas—the record is 39. Prides often split into subgroups to search for food or explore their range.

Hunting as a team

Lions are the only big cats to hunt cooperatively. In larger prides, most kills are made by the faster, lighter females. Lions stalk grazing mammals in teams, leaping onto the back of prey or seizing its legs and rear, and delivering a suffocating bite to its throat when it is grounded. Kills are shared between pride members, and an adult consumes 33–44 lb (15–20 kg) of meat at a sitting. Because lions hunt mostly at night, they doze in the shade during the day. They also scavenge the carcasses of dead animals.

Synchronized litters

The lionesses in a pride become sexually receptive at the same time, resulting in synchronized births, after an average gestation of 110 days. Each female has up to

Lions can be **recognized** by their **whisker-spot patterns**, which are as **unique as human fingerprints**

six cubs in a litter, although two or three is usual. Male lions leave the pride that they were born into at 2–4 years old and form a coalition with several other males. These coalitions roam in search of prides to take over and lead, sometimes fighting a bloody battle to oust resident males. After a takeover, the new males kill any existing cubs in the pride so the lionesses come back into estrus and so are ready to mate again.

The population of lions in Africa has gone down from 100,000 just 50 years ago to fewer than 30,000 today. This is due to hunting, a decline in their prey, and persecution by local people in retaliation for attacks on their livestock. Lions have long since vanished from North Africa and the Middle East. In Asia, they now survive only in the Gir Forest area of northwest India.

▷ KING OF THE SAVANNA

Adult males develop a long, shaggy mane around their head and neck. Their territorial roar can be heard up to 3 miles (5 km) away.



△ LIONESS WITH CUBS

Cubs stay with their mother for 20–30 months, but they may suckle from several adult females in the pride until they are weaned.

▷ HUNTING IMPALA

When chasing prey, lionesses may accelerate to a speed of 28 mph (45 km/h). Such sprints are short; rarely more than 650 ft (200 m).



- ↔ 5–8 ft (1.6–2.5 m)
- ⚖ 330–550 lb (150–250 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🐾 Mammals, carrion
- 🏠 🌿 🌳 🌴 🌵



Sub-Saharan Africa (excluding Congo Rainforest), NW. India